

Tom Clancy's
RAINBOW SIX
VEGAS

After last year's insultingly easy *Lockdown*, the *Rainbow Six* franchise had pretty much fallen in our eyes; *Vegas*, however, redeems it, and then some. While the approach has definitely shifted in favour of action rather than tactics, it retains most of its don't-go-in-with-guns-blazing heart. You play Logan Keller, the new Rainbow Six squad leader, and you must take your team through gruelling missions in the slums of Mexico and beneath the lights of Las Vegas. The game follows a (very weak) storyline, rather than just a bunch of unrelated missions—stop the terrorists before they can unleash their Doomsday Device™ upon the world. Yawn.

Undoubtedly the best feature of this game is the new “cover” system. Hold down the right mouse button, and Keller hugs the wall, and you switch to a third person view, from whence you can survey the situation by peeking round corners, or just sticking your gun out and randomly firing to suppress the enemy. All this is very reminiscent of *Gears of War*,

and works just as brilliantly. Switching between third- and first-person views is seamless, but does get disorienting if you do it too much.

Vegas is also a good bit tougher than *Lockdown*, though you won't notice this initially. Your health now regenerates while not in combat, albeit very slowly, so don't expect it to be your ticket to clearing a mission with ease. Normal difficulty is challenging, but it's Realistic that you want to play—three or four bullets (or a single head-shot) are enough to take you down. However, if you use cover properly, there's no reason for you to get killed even in Realistic mode. You now have some cool moves up your sleeve, including the ability to rappel down buildings, either to survey the situation or score some kills. You can also heal team members when they're down, but the blighters don't return the favour. The enemy AI keeps things interesting, but they're not exceptionally difficult to take down when you keep track of their tactics.

When you get done with the Story Mode, try out the Terrorist

Hunt—these are exactly what they sound like—skirmishes with bands of terrorists—and you can choose any of the game's environments to play out. Plenty of action and insanely fun, these add a lot to the game's replay value, and are good practise for multiplayer mode, should you have the bandwidth.

The game looks gorgeous, environments are well-engineered, enemy AI can be nasty at times, teammates aren't idiots, and gameplay is elegant—there's little reason, if any, for you to not buy this game.

nimish_chandiramani@thinkdigit.com

Rating: 9/10

Developer: Ubisoft Montreal

Publisher: Ubisoft

Distributor: E-Xpress Interactive

Contact: sales@e-xpressindia.com

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Minimum System Requirements:

P4 3GHz or AMD Equivalent, 1 GB RAM, 128MB, Shader Model 3 and DirectX 9.0c compatible video card